

Special cases

Organizing words according to their initial letters does not always work. For example, abbreviations, capital letters, and numerals need to be treated in special ways. In all cases, however, it is important to be consistent.

king cobra
kingfisher
king penguin

If terms consist of more than one word, treat them as if they were written without the space. In this example, the list is arranged by looking at the fifth letter.

Treat capitalized words in exactly the same way as lowercase words.

blueberry
Coconut Island
date

Hague, The
Hamburg
High Wycombe

If a phrase contains an article, such as *the*, ignore it and sort by the second word.

Sacramento
St. (Saint) Helier
Salzburg

Names of people are arranged by surnames, so the first name comes after the comma.

Dahl, Roald
Meyer, Stephenie
Twain, Mark

Arrange any abbreviated terms as if they were spelled out.

Π (Pi)
101 Dalmations
Toy Story

Collect terms with symbols or numerals at the beginning.

The dictionary

A dictionary is a collection of words and their definitions in alphabetical order. The words are arranged this way to make it easier for somebody to find a word and check its spelling or definition.

handwriting
writing done by hand, not typed or printed

The first three letters begin with the letters *han*, but the fourth letter *d* in *handwriting* comes before the letter *g* in *hang*.

hang
to support something from above

This word appears after the four-letter word *hang* because it has a fifth letter, *a*.

hangar
a very large building where aircraft are stored

Ignore the hyphen (-) and arrange the word by the fifth letter, *g*.

hang-glider
a huge kite that a person can hang from

The third letter *p* comes after the third letter *n* in *hang-glider*.

happen
to take place

The fifth letter *y* comes after the fifth letter *e* in *happen*, so this is the last word.

happy
pleased and content

REAL WORLD

Indexes



An index is a list of important topics in a reference book that is arranged in alphabetical order. Next to each key topic, a page number (or several page numbers) refers to the location of that key topic in the book. This makes it quicker and easier for the reader to find specific information.